

ART & CULTURE



BASICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

MODULE - 2

- CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE
- CULTURAL IDENTITY, RELIGION, REGION AND ETHNICITY

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE



- 1** Indian Culture includes intellectual, social aspect and spiritual impulses of every Indian.
- 2** India is a vast country with lot of diversity in physical and social environment.
- 3** We see people around us speaking different languages having different religions and practising different rituals.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE



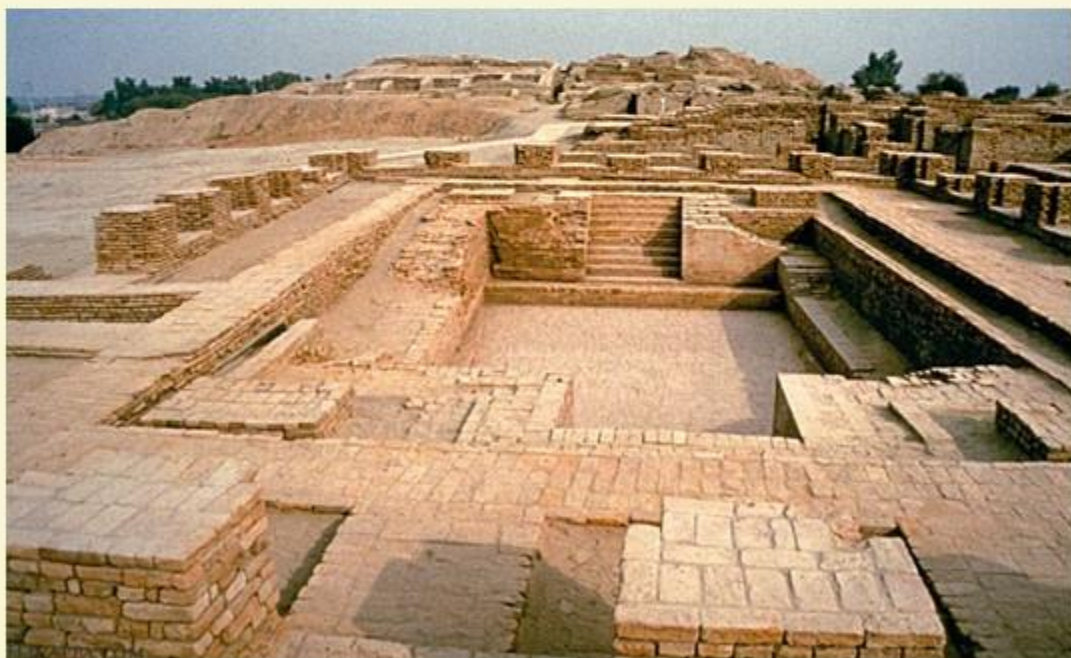
- 4 There are myriad forms of dance and music in the country but within all these diversities there is an underlying unity, which acts as a cementing force.
- 5 The intermingling of people has been steadily taking place over centuries in India. This has strengthened the composite and dynamic character of Indian culture.
- 6 The distinctive features of the Indian Culture and its uniqueness are the precious possessions of all Indians.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

1

CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

- 1 Many great cultures have developed in different countries across the world, many of them have perished or have been replaced by other cultures. However, Indian Culture has had an **enduring character**.



- 2 Despite major changes or upheavals **significant threads of continuity can be traced throughout the course of Indian history**.

- 3 You may have read about the Harappan Civilization which flourished in the Indian subcontinent many years ago.

- 4 What is amazing is that even today the pattern of house in an Indian village is not very different from that of the house of the Harappan civilization.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

1

CONTINUITY AND CHANGE



- 5 Some worships of the Harappan culture such as the worshipping the Mother Goddess and Pasupathi are still practiced.
- 6 Similarly Vedic, Buddhist, and Jain traditions continued to be followed even today.
- 7 At the same time one should not lose site of the changes as are evident in multi-storey buildings in the metropolitan cities like Mumbai and Delhi quite unlike the Harappan houses.
- 8 The point to be noted here is that continuity and change in our civilization has gone hand-in-hand.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

1

CONTINUITY AND CHANGE



9 Thus, a remarkable feature of the Indian culture is that along with continuity it has kept on changing whereas basic spirit of our culture continued.

10 It has kept on **discarding** what has become **irrelevant** in the modern age.

11 The reform movements in the Vedic religion brought about by Jainism and Buddhism and the religious and social awakening in the 18th and 19th centuries in the Modern India are a few example when **revolutionary changes** took about in Indian thoughts and practices.

12 Thus, a process of continuity and change has always been a feature of Indian culture.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



- 1 India has successfully integrated a variety of cultural elements into itself and still maintained its unity of diverse elements.
- 2 You may perhaps wonder why the people of Kerala use coconut oil while the people of Uttar Pradesh use mustard oil for cooking.
- 3 This is because Kerala's coastal state and coconut grows here plenty while in Uttar Pradesh it is a plain area which is favourable for the growth of mustard.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY

4

What is the similarity of Bhangra dance of Punjab or the Pongal of Tamil Nadu or the Bihu dance of Assam. All are celebrated and practiced after a rich harvest of crops.



CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



5 Have you noticed that the different languages that we speak like Bengali, Tamil, Gujarati or Telugu. A large number of languages and dialect are spoken in our country which has led to the growth of great variety of literature.

6 People belonging to 8 great religions of the world coexist here in a harmonious manner.

7 Numerous styles of architecture and sculptures and paintings have developed here.

Why is there so much variety in our culture?

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



① NEGROIDS



② PROTO AUSTRALOIDS



③ MONGOLOIDS



④ CAUCASOIDS

8 The vastness of the country and the variation in its physical and climatic features is an obvious reason for the variety.

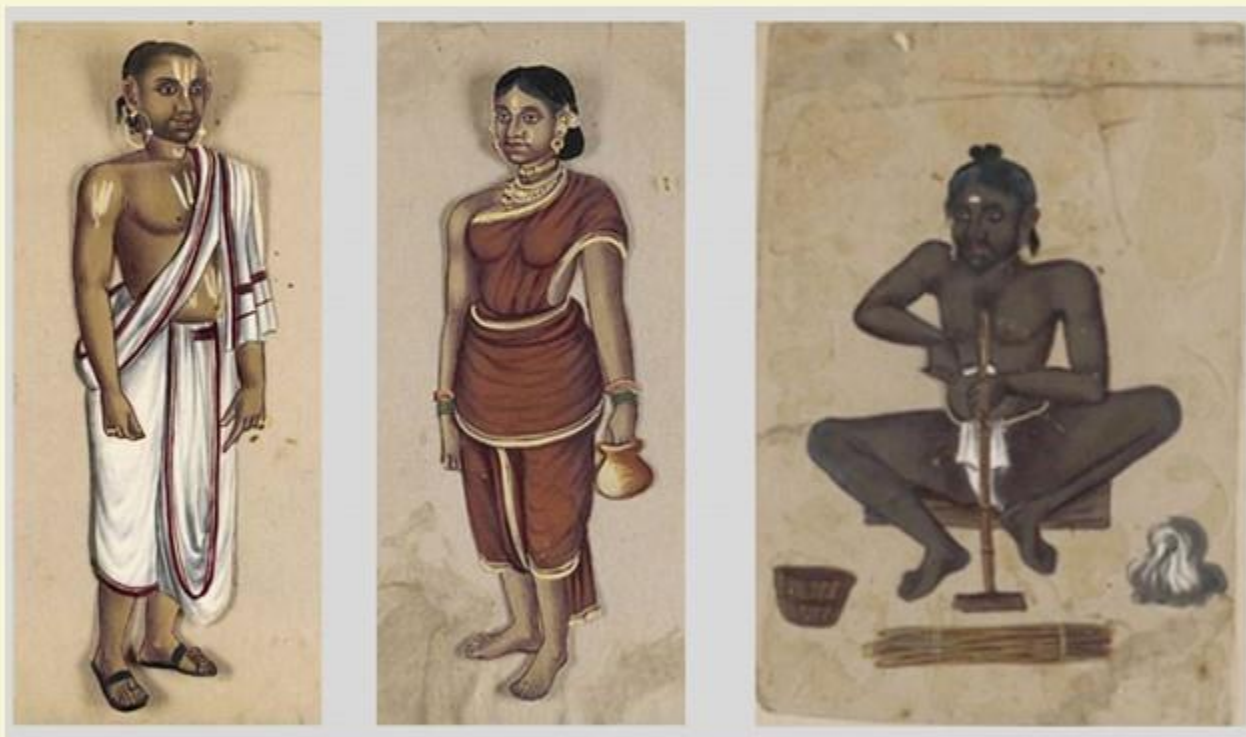
9 The second reason could be the intermingling among various ethnic groups. We find people belonging to different races like the Proto-Australoids, the Negroids and the Mongoloids living in India.

10 The people belonging to other cultures brought their cultural habits, which got amalgamated into the existing culture.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



11 Stitched clothes such as salwars, kurtas, caps (topees), etc. were brought to India, by the Kushanas and Shakas.

12 Prior to that **Indians wore clothes which were unstitched**. The latest is the introduction of shirts and trousers which were brought by the Europeans in the 18th Century.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY

13 The Chikan work of Lucknow, Phulkari embroidery of Punjab show a distinct regional flavour.



DESCRIPTION:

Above: Chikan work

Right side: Phulkari work



CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY

- 14** In spite of the physical barriers, Indians used to **travel from one part of the country to another** for trade or pilgrimage.

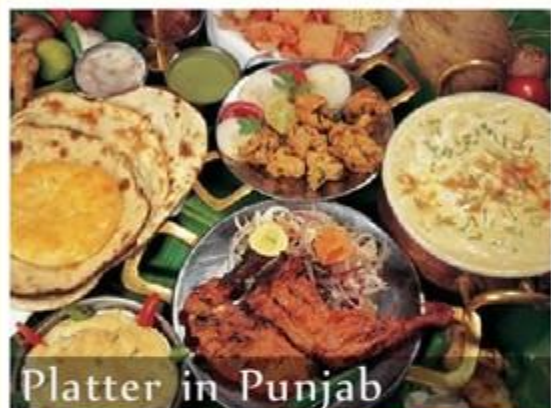


- 15** **Military campaigns** too took people from one place to another. This helped in exchanging ideas.
- 16** Such contacts have led to the development of **commonness** in Indian culture.
- 17** Another unifying factor is **climate**. The **system of monsoons** is the most important component of the Indian climatic pattern and this gives unity to the whole country.
- 18** The coming of the monsoon has ensured that **agriculture** remains the main occupation for the people of India.

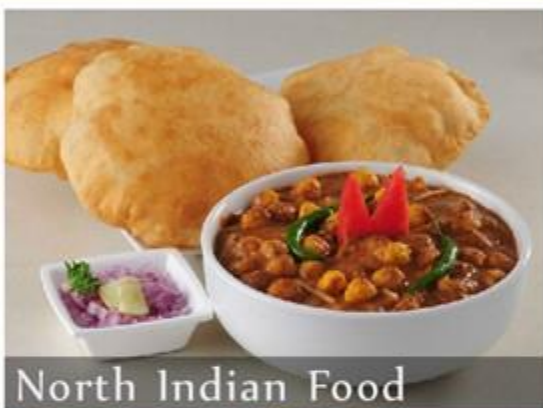
CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



Platter in Punjab



North Indian Food



Platter in Rajasthan



South Indian Food

19 On the other hand the differences in relief features have affected the food habits, dress, houses and economic activities of people.

20 This led to the uniqueness of the social, economic and political institutions, which influenced the thinking and philosophy of the people.

21 Thus, the variety in physical features and climate of India has led to the development of a variety of cultures in different regions.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



22 Unity in diversity is reflected in our political form also.

23 During the **early Vedic period**, society was **pastoral**, i.e. people move from place to place in search of pastures.

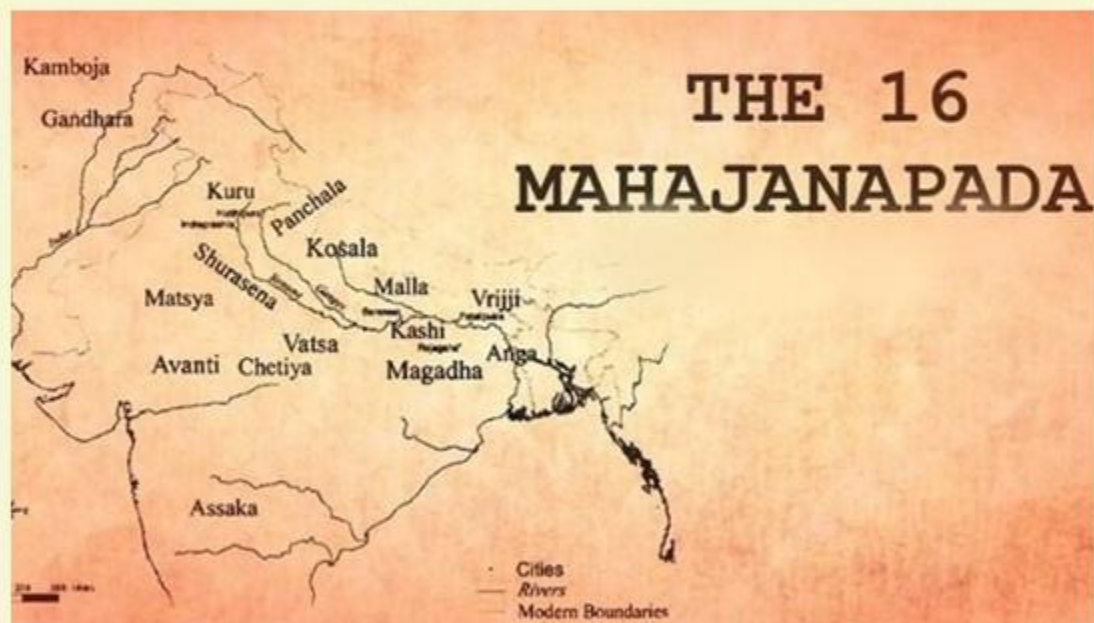
24 Later, they practised **settled agriculture**. This settled life **led to community development and growth of towns**. Thus emerged a political organisation which included the **political bodies of sabhas and samiti**.

25 In course of time, the **concept of “rashtra”** emerged and **possession of territory became the new measure of power**.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

2

VARIETY AND UNITY



26 The period from 6th to 4th century BC is known as the age of Mahajanapadas in India.

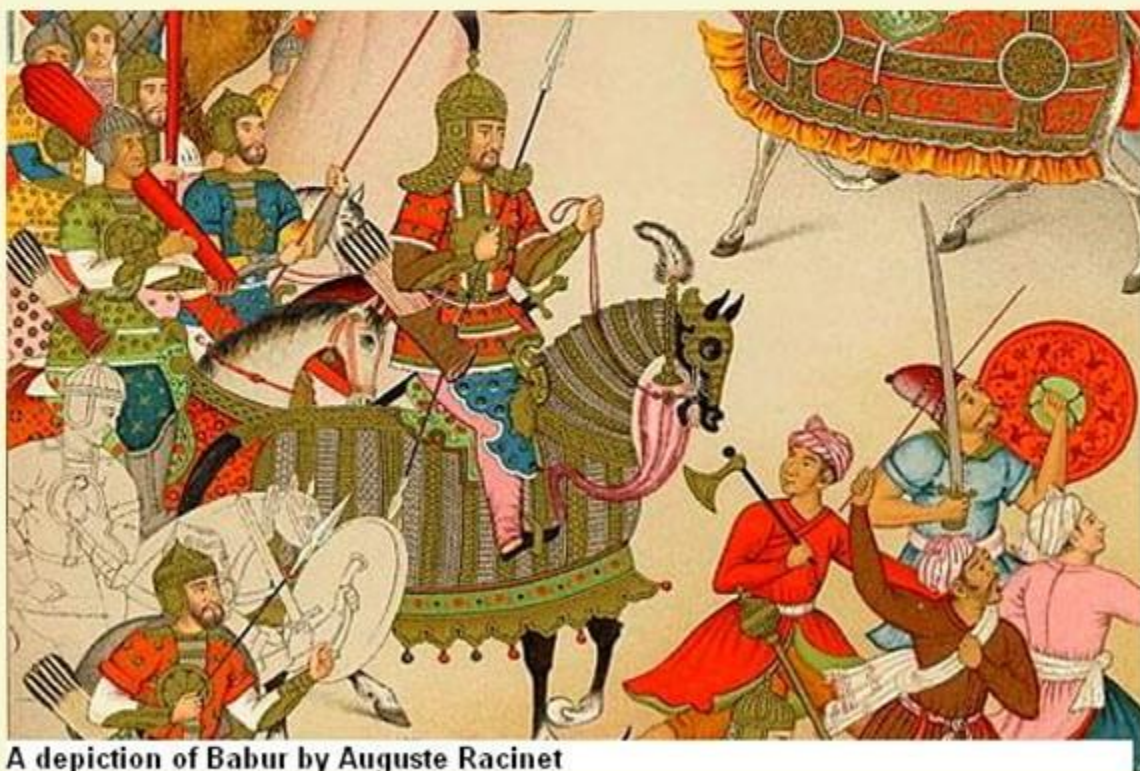
27 Subsequently, large empires were also established with emperors exercising absolute powers. E.g. Ashoka, Harsha etc.

28 The British established themselves in India and in 1858 India became a part of the British Empire. Post 1947, when we got independence till today we are a sovereign, socialist, secular and democratic republic.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

3

SECULAR OUTLOOK



A depiction of Babur by Auguste Racinet

- 1 The secular character of Indian culture is a result of intermingling of people belonging to diverse cultural groups over long period of time.
- 2 The popular cultural traditions of India are the best example of such **cultural synthesis**.
- 3 Among such a variety of people dominance of one particular religious thought is not possible. The Constitution declares India to be secular country.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

3

SECULAR OUTLOOK



4

The State has no religion of its own and all religions are treated equally by the State.

5

Right to Freedom of Religion ensures the secular nature of our country. In the western context, secularism meant complete separation of church and the State.

6

In India secularism is taken as the more positive concept to cope with the complex social structure in the country with a view to protect the interest of all and particularly the minorities.



CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

4

UNIVERSALISM



1 India has a **universal outlook** and it has been **promoting the message of peace and harmony** to the entire world.

2 We raised a strong voice against racialism and colonialism. In fact, India is one of the **founder members of the Non-Aligned Movement**.

3 India is committed to the development of other underdeveloped nations. In this manner India has been discharging her responsibilities as a part of the world fraternity.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

5

MATERIALISTIC AND SPIRITUALISTIC



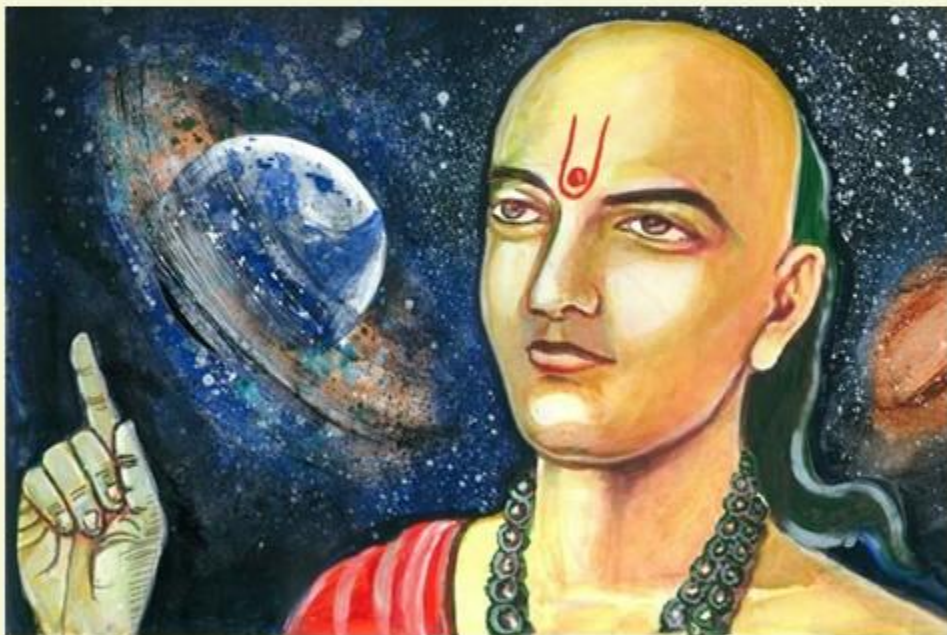
1 India is popularly known to be a Land of Spirituality, particularly to the West. However, the Indian history from the ancient times to the present day shows that the development of materialistic and non-materialistic culture have been going on alongside.

2 You will recall that the Harappan civilization was an urban civilization. It had a systematic town planning where roads cut each other at right angles. They had a profound knowledge of weights and measures.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

5

MATERIALISTIC AND SPIRITUALISTIC



3

They had an elaborate drainage system. They were aware of external trade.

4

Scientific development in our country have also taken place alongside.

Discoveries of theories like “earth rotates around the sun” or “earth is round” were made by Indians long before Europe accepted them.

5

Similarly, in the area of mathematics and in the field of medicines India’s achievements in ancient times have been remarkable. There was no opposition or resistance by religious thoughts in pursuing such scientific knowledge.

CHARACTERISTICS OF INDIAN CULTURE

5

MATERIALISTIC AND SPIRITUALISTIC

6

Even in philosophical thought
atheistic thinking developed in India.

7

All these tells us that Indian culture
has been both materialistic and non-
materialistic or spiritualistic.



CULTURAL IDENTITY, RELIGION, REGION AND ETHNICITY



- 1** Our cultural identities are based on various factors such as religion and region. As a result each Indian possesses multiple identities.
- 2** Which of these identities assert itself at a certain point of time, depends on the political, social or economic context in which the person finds himself/herself.
- 3** Thus Brahmins in Tamil Nadu are quite different from Brahmins in Kashmir. Similarly, Muslims in Kerala and Uttar Pradesh may have dissimilarities in several aspects irrespective of the fact that they have a common religion connecting them which is Islam.

CULTURAL IDENTITY, RELIGION, REGION AND ETHNICITY



- 4 Here regional identities take much stronger roots than religious identities.
- 5 People of different religions and caste may have common regional cultural traits like language, food, dress, values etc. For example in Bengal, both Hindus and Muslims take pride in being Bengalis and they will share several elements of Bengali culture.
- 6 Ethnic culture is strong among the tribal groups. For example, in the small State of Nagaland, there are more than a dozen tribes and they differ from each other in their dress, language and beliefs. Bastar district of Chhattisgarh has several groups claiming different ethnic origins.

CULTURAL INFLUENCES



- 1** In the modern context, there are at least three significant influences on our culture. They are westernisation, emergent national cultural styles and popular culture.
- 2** The current influence of westernization because of modern globalization has left certain impact on our culture. The growing demand for English medium schools in the villages is a proof of this statement.
- 3** During the struggle for freedom a new style emerged. For example the Gandhi cap and khadi may now be a ceremonial symbol, but back then it contributed to the unity of the country and provided commonness to culture.

CULTURAL INFLUENCES

- 4 Popular culture, the product of mass media, is also another unifying factor. The **impact of films** on the present day youth has been tremendous.



- 5 Radio and television along with the modern media like **social networking platforms** also re-shape or attitude towards culture.



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